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IARCO RESEARCH PROPOSAL

Full Legal Name: Khant Zayar Linn

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Research Title: Assessing the impact of hybrid learning environment on the psychological experiences and developments, especially self-confidence, among adolescents aged 13 – 19 in Yangon region, Myanmar

Abstract

Hybrid learning has started to be increasingly implemented in education sector, yet its effects on self-confidence and psychological experiences among adolescents aged 13 - 19 in Myanmar, remain underexplored. This research aims to assess whether hybrid learning environment has truly evolved better than the traditional face-to-face learning or online learning individually. A mixed-methods approach will be conducted involving four classes of students:

1. Class where students regularly attend school on campus
2. Class where students regularly attend online at their own comfort
3. Class where students attend for up to three days online and the remaining days on campus
4. Class where students attend for up to three days on campus and the remaining days online

The study will provide extremely relevant local evidence on how hybrid learning shapes students' confidence and psychological experiences in Yangon region, Myanmar.

Introduction

The development of digital technology has progressively changed the educational paradigms, creating significant transformation that extend beyond the traditional face-to-face classroom environment. The transition became particularly evident during the COVID-19 pandemic. For adolescents aged 13 – 19, however, changes in learning environment affected them more than their academic performance. Benner *et al.* [1] found that adolescents and young adults commonly faced alterations in academic outcomes and school relationships during the pandemic. Similarly, Cortés-Albornoz *et al.* [2] reported the association of online learning with changes in students' academic, motivational, and socio-emotional experiences.

In the aftermath, as schools resumed the physical classrooms, the elements of online learning increasingly became integrated with classroom teaching rather than the online environment being dropped, evolving into a hybrid learning environment. Students can now attend their classes leisurely from their own house or on campus for traditional learning experience. This change has raised countless questions not only about its impact on students' academic achievement but also about the students' psychological developments. Much research has been conducted, indicating that the influence of a learning environment may also amount to how students perceive themselves as a whole [3], [4]. This is particularly important during adolescence, a period in which students increasingly develop independence, self-perception, and trust in their abilities. Thus, self-confidence becomes an important aspect to examine within hybrid learning. For students aged 13 – 19, their confidence may be reflected in every action they accomplish, in every conversation they make, and in approaching every academic challenge.

While recent studies have discovered the connections between hybrid learning and academic achievements, limited research has been made specifically on the impact of hybrid learning on student's self-confidence. This correlation is extremely relevant in the context of Myanmar, where the hybrid learnings have begun to be introduced, especially in international schools. Therefore, this situation provides a distinctive opportunity to study the effects of hybrid learning on the self-confidence of developing students aged 13 – 19, guaranteeing original and reliable results.

Literature review

Hybrid learning is found to influence students' psychological experiences, particularly their confidence in participating and managing learning tasks. Fitriyana *et al.* [5] and Adamu *et al*. [6] found that the effects of hybrid learning on self-efficacy and self-regulated learning are positively promising and effective. Nur *et al.* [7], established that online-based hybrid learning could increase participation and reduce anxiety among students with higher self-confidence. On the other hand, students with lower self-confidence continued to experience fear of judgment and making accidental mistakes despite the flexibility of hybrid learning [7]. Moreover, Ortega *et al.* [8] reported generally high self-efficacy toward hybrid, despite some students still experienced difficulty concentrating and preferred direct interaction with teachers and classmates.

A study comparing between hybrid and fully online education has also linked hybrid learning with psychological factors and found lower depression levels in the hybrid group, despite no significant differences were discovered regarding self-respect, academic pressure or anxiety [9]. This implies that face-to-face interaction within hybrid learning environment may offer benefits to students' psychological well-being, but does not spontaneously improve psychological welfare [9]. Furthermore, a study of school-age students found lower psychological burdens among students in hybrid and in-person learning compared with fully virtual learning [10]. These contrasting findings suggest that hybrid learning may effectively provide psychological benefits through continued social and teacher interaction, while its impacts can also largely depend on students' circumstances and the way hybrid learning is being implemented.

Research gaps

Although existing studies present promising improvements in self-efficacy, participation, and confidence through hybrid learning [5], [6], [7], the psychological effects are not consistently positive across all students, with some continuing to experience anxiety, fear of judgment, or low confidence, [7], [9] . Furthermore, much of the existing research focuses on university students or specific subjects, [6], [7], [9], leaving limited evidence on adolescents aged 13 - 19. Therefore, further research is needed to examine how hybrid learning influences self-confidence and other psychological experiences among students within this age group.

Moreover, there is limited research on the psychological effects of hybrid learning in Myanmar, particularly among secondary-school students. Existing Myanmar related research has largely inspected the disruption and implementation of online or hybrid education rather than students' self-confidence and psychological experiences. This leaves little or no evidence on how hybrid learning affects adolescents aged 13 - 19 in the Myanmar context, where access to technology, learning conditions, and educational circumstances may differ from those examined in existing international studies. Therefore, investigating students' self-confidence and psychological experiences in Myanmar could provide incredibly relevant local evidence that is currently limited in the case studies and past research to help conclude on whether the hybrid learning is beneficial to Myanmar students' psychological well-being compared to conventional and online learning environments.

Research questions

1. How do students' self-confidence levels in hybrid learning compare across different age groups or grade levels within the 13 - 19 age range?
2. How do students' self-confidence in hybrid learning compare to their recalled or perceived self-confidence during prior fully online or traditional face-to-face learning environments?
3. Is there a statistically significant difference in students' self-reported confidence during online activities while attending online versus during in-person classroom sessions within a hybrid learning environment?
4. How do psychological factors, such as social anxiety, fear of making mistakes and of peer judgment, affect classroom participation in hybrid learning environment?

Proposed Methodology

Research design

This study will be using a mixed-method design amalgamating both qualitative and quantitative approaches in evaluating three learning environments: traditional face-to-face, fully online, and hybrid learning. The hybrid group will be separated again into two groups: one group will attend online for up to three days per week and attend school on campus for the remaining days while another group will attend school on campus for up to three days per week and attend online for the remaining days. Quantitative data will be collected through questionnaires and short surprise tests while qualitative data will be collected through classroom observations and open-ended responses or small interviews.

Samples to be tested

Approximately 400 volunteering students (n = 400) will be recruited and divided as evenly as possible into four groups:

1. Face-to-face group**:** students regularly attend classes on campus.
2. Online group**:** students regularly attend classes remotely.
3. Hybrid group 1**:** students regularly attend online for three days, and the remaining days on campus
4. Hybrid group 2: students regular attend on campus for three days, and the remaining days online

Criteria: Students must be 13 – 19 ages with no or minimal hybrid learning experience, especially for the hybrid groups.

Students will also be categorized by age or grade level, such as 13 - 15, 16 - 17, and 18 - 19, enabling age-related differences to be examined within and between the learning environments. Where possible, students from similar academic levels and subjects will be selected to reduce differences caused by curriculum or subject difficulty.

Necessary assessments

A structured questionnaire will be occasionally given to all participants using a 5-point Likert scale measuring:

- self-confidence in answering questions, expressing opinions and communications with teachers and classmates inside classroom
- willingness to participate in classroom activities
- social anxiety
- fear of making mistakes and of peer judgment
- perceived confidence in online and face-to-face learning

In addition, classroom observations will be conducted with the help of educators and parents if the subjects are attending online. This method will provide observable behaviours, such as volunteering answers, asking questions and contributing to discussions, and interacting with classmates. The observers will only judge students' personalities or psychological conditions visible classroom behaviours will be recorded.

To provide an additional behavioural measurement, several short, unannounced classroom tests online, on campus or both will also be conducted during the study. These will be brief and based on material taught recently rather than difficult examinations. Students' willingness to attempt questions, remaining steadfast, and asking for clarification (if there were any confusions) will be recorded alongside their test performance.

Data analysis

Quantitative data from questionnaire, and classroom observations will be summarised using means, percentages, and standard deviations. Self-confidence scores will be compared across the three learning environments using ANOVA, or the Kruskal-Wallis test if required. Paired tests will compare students' confidence between online and in-person classes within the hybrid group and, where relevant, with their recalled confidence from previous learning environments. Correlation analysis will examine relationships between classroom participation and anxiety, fear of mistakes and of peer judgment.

Qualitative data from classroom observations will be converted into participation frequencies and compared with students' questionnaire responses. This will help determine whether students who report higher confidence also demonstrate more observable participation. Surprise tests will also be used as additional evidence for finding correlation between confidence and learning environment to support the conclusion.

Ethical considerations

Participation will be voluntary, with appropriate parental or guardian consent and student assent obtained for participants under 18. Students will be informed about the purpose and procedures of the study and may withdraw at any time. No unnecessary identifying information will be collected. Questionnaire responses, interviews, and observations will be kept confidential and

11 used only for research purposes. The surprise tests will be and unrelated to academic grades so that they do not create unnecessary pressure. Students will not be individually ranked or publicly compared. Since the study discusses anxiety, confidence, and fear of judgment, participants may skip questions that make them uncomfortable. The research will examine self-reported psychological experiences and will not diagnose mental-health conditions.

Potential limitations

Students cannot be randomly assigned to learning environments if the groups are based on their existing schools or classes. Therefore, differences between groups may also result from factors such as teaching style, school resources, internet access, family environment, or previous learning experiences. Self-reported confidence and recalled experiences may also contain response and recall bias. Classroom observations may be influenced by the observer's interpretation, so a standardized checklist will be used. The short tests may also create temporary anxiety or differences in performance unrelated to confidence. It should be noted that these findings may not represent all students aged 13 - 19 in Myanmar as the sample is only drawn from a limited number of students in Yangon region.

Project timeline

This study will be conducted across 6 months.

Month **0**: Planning: Finalize research questions, review existing literature, and prepare the research plan and materials
: Collect consent forms from guardians and school authorities
Month **1** to **5**: Data collection and methodology carefully carried out
Month **2** – **3**: Halfway check for procedures and data
Month **6**: Analyse quantitative and qualitative data, compare findings, interpret results, and conclude the study

Each month, the progress of work will be checked and ensure the methodology is followed correctly and carefully.

Conclusion

This study will investigate how hybrid learning shapes the self-confidence and psychological experiences of students aged 13 - 19 in Myanmar, comparing traditional face-to-face, fully online, and hybrid learning environments. By combining measurable evidence with students' real psychological experiences, the research aims to discover not only whether hybrid learning changes students' confidence, but what drives those changes**.** Ultimately, the study seeks to present meaningful and highly local related evidence that can help educators create learning environments where students feel confident to participate, communicate, and learn**.**

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